

Myths and legends

Dinosaurs in the Congo? Abominable snowmen in the mountains? Ever since people began telling stories, there have been tales of fantastic animals. While many are just tall tales about mythical beasts that never existed, some might just have a grain of truth in them—they may be ancient stories from a time when long-lost prehistoric animals still lived.



Robert Plot thought this fossil was the knee-end of a giant human's thigh bone.



WHAT'S THAT?

The first dinosaur was not correctly identified until the 1800s—until then, people had no idea what fossils were. A famous description and picture of what was later identified as a dinosaur bone was published in 1677 by the English naturalist Robert Plot. He claimed it was part of the thigh bone of a human giant.

Half human, half ape

From Sasquatch (Bigfoot) in North America to the Yeti in the Himalayas and Orang Pendek in Sumatra, tales of mysterious ape-men are common around the world. Some scientists believe the origin of these old stories might lie in the distant past, when humans spread from Africa to other parts of the world and came across our living “hominin” relatives, including Neanderthals and *Homo erectus*.

